Pillow talk

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/34154242.

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Mature

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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by missymay

Summary

Well, perhaps Catra hadn't heard. Or better yet, she thinks Adora was joking – it's the kind of deadpan humour that Catra loves. Maybe she'll crack up and praise the blonde's unwavering wit, then they both sit too close with hot tea and gay-coded children's shows while brainstorming realistic methods of saving money. And maybe that was optimistic, but Adora has often considered herself a lucky woman.

She turns to peek into the kitchen where Catra had stilled mid-pour. Rigid.

Fuck.

Adora does not consider herself a lucky woman.

OR: Catra and Adora are poor college students. Adora suggests they share a bed. Confessions ensue.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Okay, Adora isnt a characteristically subtle person.

(Catra mentioned this often.)

When asked to "describe herself in 3 words", subtle didnt make the cut. Subtle didnt push the top 100. *Subtle* didnt emerge even in a limitless vocabulary of Adora's psyche. But this…

"We could always sell a bed."

Adora slaps her mouth shut. Oh. Oh no. This is the immeasurably polar fucking opposite to subtle.

Well, perhaps Catra hadnt heard. Or better yet, she thinks Adora was joking – it's the kind of deadpan humour that Catra loves. Maybe shell crack up and praise the blonde's unwavering wit, then they both sit too close with hot tea and gay-coded children's shows while brainstorming realistic methods of saving money. And maybe that was optimistic, but Adora has often considered herself a lucky woman. She turns to peek into the kitchen where Catra had stilled mid-pour. Rigid. *Fuck.*

Adora does not consider herself a lucky woman. She swallows, bracing for inevitable admonishment:

'I think it's best that we keep our own beds.'

'You're my best friend Adora. But only my friend.'

What the fuck?

'I think we need some space.'

‘You should leave. Like now. Forever.’

Adora knows she’s being dramatic, but she knows that Catra is too. She is also anxiously aware of the other girl’s ability to read her; a skill honed by both parties over a lifetime of friendship, minus a fraction.

(They had clashed at the forced reunion. A reckless and fleeting collision of pride and stubbornness, not dissimilar to the fights that drove them apart a year prior. There was misplaced anger at each other, at their rooming situation, at the entirety of the foster system, but once the dust had settled, the past scars had been stitched firm, final and healthy. “Who knew communication could get you so far?” Glimmer had said. The right side of Glimmer’s face, Catra had slapped. At the conclusion of their second semester, Catra and Adora had declared themselves indefinite roommates, and life-long friends. Best friends. The bestest of friendsies with a secret and unrequited, undying romantic love. Which was supposed to remain secret.)

Even without Catra-level attunement to Adora’s dialogue, the subtext of the proposal was very fucking obvious: What if you sell your bed and move into mine and sleep with me and oh by the way I have been desperately in love with you for most of our friendship and can we get married and live together forever?

Before Adora can spiral further, the burbling sound of boiling water resumes. She whips her gaze back to the kitchen where Catra is completely still, stiff, controlled, as steam hisses and billows around her. Just pouring tea.

Adora cant see her face, but she' s not sure she wants to. If only to suspend a moment of hope before she turns and everything shatters. To award Catra a moment of privacy until she decides how best to let Adora down.

And then she turns, and she is blank.

No scowl. No trace of disgust or relief. If anything, her brows are imprinted with faux relaxation – this woman has evocative eyebrows – and the twitch of her ear spells nervousness. Strange. Stranger still, the brunette floats through the lounge, teacups in tow, and nestles into her designated couch crater. Adora can only bemusedly watch her friend. She expected, well, some reaction, but the brunette only rests her mouth on the porcelain and quietly sips. Adora is resolutely not watching her lips.

"I dont think we can find a cheaper mattress, honestly ."

Oh, Catra thinks-

"No, I meant we could just share."

Stupid! Adora is idiotic. Catra gave her an out, and she doubled down and corrected her. She peers up from Catra's lips – when did that happen? – to meet only her side profile. The brunette is fixedly angled towards the TV. The gloss of her eyes forms an impermeable barrier to the screen, like the story cant quite reach her mind; and Adora gets the feeling that Catra isnt really watching at all. She knows this look: Catra is calculating. Dissecting Adora' s words for the arcane implication she so often injects. The blonde is usually

happy to pause;content to watch her friend confused and unguarded, and when Catra deciphers the words, her knowing smirk makes the wait and the teasing a welcome concession.

But Adora isnt currently the epitome of patience. And Adora certainly doesnt want time enough for Catra to figure out the meaning of her words –the chance for which is rapidly expiring. So, before the other girl can respond-

"I mean, just while it' s winter, and- and then we can save for another bed in summer."She gestures at nothing. "Y ou know?W e can just cuddle for body heat, until we can afford to-"

"Y ou want to cuddle"? Catra is watching her now. Not that hazy and unfocused gaze from moments ago;she eyes Adora with sober interest.

Adora meets her scrutiny. "I want to save money ."She says, following the gradual raise of Catra's brow. "And Im not against cuddling. We've cuddled on the couch before, it' s not a big deal." Indifference, that's good. Adora totally does not fantasize about holding Catra, or stroking her hair until she falls asleep, or holding her up as –no. She doesnt care.

Catra's expression remains disbelieving. "W e've cuddled on the couch properly, like, 6 times. And the couch is big. We have twin size beds, Adora."

Adora laughs. "Didnt know we were keeping count."Catra rolls her eyes, and she looks ready to scoff and interject- "And we can fit on a twin bed. But only.only if you're comfortable with it."A beat passes: their gazes are electrically tethered. "Are you"?

Catra softens at that, but her smirk lingers. "I'd be literally on top of you."

That’s not an answer, but Adora knows that for Catra, it kind of is.

“I know .”

“Like, I would crush you.” Adora giggles.

“I can live with that.” Catra is tempted, and she is dismantling every half-assed doubt.

The charged eye contact snaps as the brunette finally raises her drink again in a long, languid sip. Adora takes the opportunity to taste her own. It’s a new blend, a present from their latest and final dorm party, one of many boxes under the hand-drawn banner – “we survived college dorms!” – but it had taken a week to open it. Perfuma had rejected the joking and platonic pretense of the party , it was a recognition of an ending. Adora had spoken of ‘closing the book’ of this story , a metaphor for which she was quite proud, but Perfuma had only shaken her head and softly corrected her. Not the end, just the start of your next chapter .’

She gifted the tea with a knowing look, and Adora regretted ever confessing her feelings to her friends.

(Not really. It was relieving to share her secret, like the lifelong knot of guilt and dread in her gut was loosened as she sobbed, and sobbed. Her friends held her through it. They shared words of assurance, so much so that their wisdom and understanding became contagious -even Mermista joined in - and Adora began to believe them. When she arrived at the dorm close to midnight, tear stained and ragged, Catra had jumped to her side. Adora hugged her . Tight. And for the first time she didn’t hate herself for it.

Also, she isn’t sure if they would have received such a high-quality green tea if Perfuma saw their apartment plans as strictly platonic.

Which they were, as Adora assured, but her friends had none of it.)

Whatever, the drink is great. Fantastic, even.

The blonde realises the length of silence that has elapsed in her tea-induced daydream, though she imagines Catra was having much the same reaction. She sees the other girl staring into the swirling leaves, contemplation wiping her expression blank.

"Good tea, right?"

"What about sex?"

Adora chokes.

Catra's eyes flicker to where Adora is thumping her chest. She's alive, though barely. "What?" She manages between splutters.

Catra sighs. "Sex. How would we..." Adora muffles her cough. Wait. Does she mean? Does she want us to- "What if you bring someone home? If there's only one bed..."

Oh, that's reasonable. But Adora can't have Catra thinking she's looking for other people, so she steadies her breath and answers, "I won't bring anyone home, Catra."

Catra's brows are knitted. "Why?"

It’s odd, Adora thinks, that her barren sexual history does not establish precedent in Catra’s mind;that a switch will flip, and her dormant lifestyle will suddenly, supposedly, erupt. “I don’t want to? I’m really not a one-night stand kind of person-”

“Yeah, but what if you get in a relationship?” Catra is relentless, and this is getting dangerous.

“Yeah, that’s not going to happen. But look, if you end up bringing someone-”

“Why won’t it happen?”

“She doesn’t like me back. Just- if you bring someone home, I can take the couch, okay? I don’t mind. You can cook me breakfast and call it even.” Adora smirks, drawing her gaze to where she knows Catra will be rolling her eyes and scoffing.

She isn’t.

Catra is wide-eyed, staring at the blonde as if blinking brings her pain.

Adora winces. “Or I can, um, go-”

"You like someone."

It's not a question.
But it's not accusing either. It registers as something close to disbelief, which is fair, Adora thinks: Catra knows she's gay – the lesbian flag in the lounge is an old pint purchase – but she's never mentioned her crushes, albeit for good reason. For Catra, this revelation is probably straight out of left field.

"Oh. yeah." It's the best she can give. She just had the air knocked from her lungs.

"You. you've never liked someone before."

Adora laughs, a little stilted. "I have." She squeezes her fists in an effort to keep the rest of her body from curling inwards. "I just… didn't tell you." It fades into a whisper at the end, barely enough for Catra to hear. She does though, if the soft hand on hers is any indicator.

"I really think we should keep our beds then." Catra says, focused on gently prying the blonde's fists open, revealing the crescent marks where her nails overhang.

Adora stares at her palms too, and now it's her brows that furrow. "What do you mean?" Catra chuckles breathily. Her thumb is stroking lazily over the dented skin.

"Trust me, you're going to want your own bed when you get together."

"Get together? She, uh, she doesnt even-"

"Oh, please, there's no way she doesnt feel the same." Catra is gripping Adora's hand now, like her words are too emphatic to contain. "You're Adora fucking Grayskull, if she cant see how incredible you are, then she's even dumber than you. And that's a scientific phenomenon." She flicks the blonde's forehead with her free hand.

Adora would probably laugh right about now, she should laugh, but she cant – not when Catra is so overwhelmingly sincere. She's anxious, and Catra is misinterpreting it as insecurity, but she doesnt know how to correct her without confessing. All she can do is try to move the conversation on.

"I know she doesnt feel the same, so the bed's not a problem for me, but what about y-" she's interrupted when Catra scoffs.

"Who is this bitch anyway?"

"Catra!"

"No, Im serious, I want to meet the woman that's making my best friend doubt herself this much. I mean, is she a fucking supermodel? You really dont have to worry about your looks Adora."

"What?- she, well" Adora is trying to formulate words despite the insinuation that *Catra thinks she's hot.* "No, she' s not a supermodel-"

"Okay so is she some incredible athlete? Cause you are." Adora opens her mouth to protest, but she's cut off instantly. "Or is she a straight-A student? Cause you are, Dr , and you work so hard for that shit." God, she has no clue of the weight her words bear . "Or is she just a really nice person, because I've literally watched you carry ducklings across the street. Twice."

It's becoming very clear to Adora that she won't get to speak on this. Catra has decided that any input the blonde has will be self-deprecating and negative, so it's best not give those thoughts any platform. She can only watch those lips sound praise so animatedly, and her heart melts, and it screams, because if she knew, if only she knew, would she still say these things?

Would Adora still be her best friend?

Catra's voice cuts through her drowning thoughts.

"I don't know this girl, but I do know you. And anyone in the world would be so lucky to love you." Catra smiles, and squeezes her hand, and all at once the contact is sending fire to her skin and it's so hot and so much and she's bursting at the soft eyes on her and – did Catra say love? -and-

She kisses her.

Fuck.

It’s so gentle, and Adora’s lips tremble like she’s resisting the raw emotion and passion she feels.
Because she is.
The love she has is crushing, but she can't hurt Catra too. It’ s not a kiss. It’s an answer, and an apology. So, she pulls away, slowly, and it means 'I'm sorry'.

There’s a taste of salt that Adora only hopes is her own.

"She doesn't love me back."She whispers between them, because the distance already feels so great, but she knows her words will reach. Her eyes are painfully shut. The face waiting to solidify the object of a lifetime’ s grief, guilt and dread is past her eyelids.

She opens them.

The first realisation to strike is that the tears on her tongue were not hers. Catra is crying, just barely , and silent, motionless but for the bead sliding down her right cheek.

She looks..broken.

And fuck, if that doesn't set Adora of f. She chokes back a sob. No, it’s Catra who should be upset, she’s been selfish enough already.

Gathering herself, and clearing her heart from her throat, is when Adora really looks at Catra. And when the second realisation hits.

"I—me?"Catra whispers back. Her lips are parted, and while her eyes are wide, there’s no trace of..anger .

Adora was prepared for anger. She could handle Catra's anger, but this was much harder – there was surprise, sure, but also – there was unmistakable hurt.

"I love you." Adora says, because she has to say it, because her stomach has fluttered for a decade with the struggle to contain the words. Because Catra asked, and she could never deny her.

A fresh tear finally falls when Catra blinks again. "Adora"…

"I'm sorry." It's all she can say really. "I'm so sorry, Catra." Heavy, her head drops, and it's quiet for a moment. Catra drops her hand. She had forgotten they were intertwined until now, and she recoils fast like she's been burned. But then Catra's fingers find her cheek, and she's beckoning Adora to look up. "I'm sorry." She repeats. Adora hurt her, but Catra is being so patient, and that's somehow worse.

Maybe this was fated. Catra was always strong and rough where Adora was soft. While Catra needs independence, Adora needs Catra. While Catra is commanding; Adora is obeying.

"Adora, look at me."

She obeys.

Her cheek is damp under Catra's palm. It should be uncomfortable, but she leans into it and feels her shoulders fall.

"I'm-"

"Don't say you're sorry ." Adora snaps her mouth shut. The brunette huffs a laugh, but she frowns shortly after. They both brace at the tension. "How , um, how long?"

Adora doesn't need her to clarify . "Always." She hears Catra' s breath catch. "But I only figured it out when we met again. Probably 2 months in."

Catra puffs her cheeks, like she has too much to say. "So, you just wanted to, what? Share a bed without confessing that you love me first?"

She raises a challenging brow, and Adora just giggles, because, well, yeah, that's exactly what she wanted. She should verbalise that though, rather than giggling like a deranged toddler. "Kind of, yeah? I was hoping that I could just... have you in whatever way you let me." There's a silence, where Catra just blinks, and Adora very suddenly stops laughing. "Oh my god. That was really predatory , wasn't it? Shit, Catra, I'm so sorry , and, and you- you are... you're, uh… smiling?"

She is. Grinning, actually. Wide and toothy and looking moments away from bursting in mirth.

She pokes the blonde's forehead. "You're an idiot."

"I- what?" She keeps poking.

"You. Are-"

"An idiot, I know. But," Adora's eyes flicker, searching the other girl's face for something. "Why aren't you mad? You should be- I don't know," Catra is muffling her laughter now, "well, not laughing! This is, like, really weird. You're acting normal!"

Catra snorts. "I'm acting normal?"

"Yeah!" *Now she gets it!* "Like nothing's changed, like I didn't just ruin our friendship." She pouts, which would be natural in literally any other of their usual exchanges.

"Like you." Catra's smile slips, like she suddenly sobered. "Yeah, no, heh, I guess you did ruin our friendship."

And Adora's not sure why she thought she wanted to win that argument. Catra's hand is gone from her forehead, and she could cry. But then it's on her jaw, and she's leaning closer, and "oh."

There's warm breath on her lips when time stops. Her senses are only Catra, Catra, Catra as she exhales, forever a whisper away, and Adora is content to breathe her air forever. But then she parts her lips, and – "say it again."

Nothing has ever been easier. "I love you."

They kiss.

It's not fireworks, but it's warm, and it's magical. Magical in the way they melt together, in the hypnotic pull of Catra's lips that's equally satiating and provoking. She's falling, Catra is a black hole; Adora is a willing traveler, and she holds Catra's face like she'll float away.

She doesn't, but she can't let go.

Adora is lost in the taste of tea and something else, something that simply must be Catra, that she doesn't notice wandering hands until one is on her waist, the other at the back of her neck. Then Catra pulls her in, like their lips aren't close enough, and her heart leaps.

Wow. If Adora were standing, her knees surely would have given out. But she's seated, curled on the couch of the living room, and kissing Catra. Kissing Catra. Kissing Catra, who's stroking Adora's nape when she finally relents and lets her hands travel. Heat rises from Adora's stomach as her fingers find Catra's waist. They settle there like missing puzzle pieces, like they belong, and Catra must have felt it too, because it's then she pulls away, breathless. Her lips are parted, and Adora has never wanted to kiss her more. Which she could, but she's not sure she should, and it's all a bit much for Adora's brain.

"I'm so confused." Adora blurts, because she is.

Catra squints at her. "I thought you were past that phase."

Adora groans. "No, I mean- What was that?" And since she knows Catra, "Don't say a kiss." Catra visibly deflates. She moves her hand to stroke the blonde's cheekbone.

“What, was I not clear enough?” Catra leans in again, placing a featherlight kiss to the corner of her mouth. “I.” Once more. “Love.” She traces Adora’s lips with her own. “You.” They meet in the middle. “Too.”

Catra’s hands could be anywhere; perhaps they hold her reverent face, or they grip and ground her waist, or curl like snakes around her hips and shoulders; Adora can’t be sure of anything when every nerve has dulled but the pressure on her mouth. Catra loves her, it’s unfathomable, so she kisses her like the dream could slip away – tender, yet desperate. But the lips on her own are very much real, solid, and they push closer rather than pulling away. While the kiss is incredible, Adora gets the feeling there will be many more, a lifetime’s worth, even, and she can’t resist another chance at teasing.

“So, I had an idea.” She starts when they part. With their foreheads pressed together, she can feel Catra hum more than she hears it, a clear signal to continue. “We could maybe, I don’t know, sell one of our beds?”

Adora can’t restrain her cocky smirk as Catra’s eyes flutter open, fingers interlaced at the blonde’s nape. Her eyes are playful as she draws a breath to respond.

“What about sex?”

They sell Adora’s bed a week later.

End Notes

This is my first fic, hope you enjoyed! I have a soft spot for roommate AUs and this was entirely self-indulgent. Nevertheless, feel free to leave any feedback in the comments :)

Thanks for reading!

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!